

MINT CONDITION

written by
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First Draft

FADE IN:

EXT. BLISS MANOR -- MONTECITO, CALIFORNIA -- DAWN

A coastal estate so large it has weather. Fountains. Topiary shaped like famous economists. A driveway you could land a Cessna on, and, judging by the windsock, someone does.

TITLE: "MINT CONDITION"

INT. BLISS MANOR -- THE HALL OF THINGS -- DAWN

A gallery the length of a bowling alley. Lit like the Louvre. And in the cases:

-- The actual puck from the Miracle on Ice.

-- A Stradivarius. Next to it, a second Stradivarius, with a small card reading "BACKUP."

-- Napoleon's smaller, angrier hat.

-- An Action Comics #1, framed beside a handwritten note from the seller that just reads "please stop calling me."

At the end of the hall, in a bathrobe over silk pajamas, stands RANDOLPH "RANDY" BLISS, 52 -- silver-maned, boyish, a face built for delight and currently not using it. He holds a smoothie he will not drink.

He is staring at the room's only EMPTY CASE.

Museum-lit. Velvet plinth. A brass plaque, already engraved, reading: "SOON."

HIS BUTLER, OSWALDO, 60s, dignified beyond all surrounding evidence, approaches with a silver tray. On the tray: a single pill bottle and a glass of water.

OSWALDO

Your seven a.m., sir. Doctor Nam reminds you it is now the half dose. She asks me to say, quote, "the taper only works if it tapers."

RANDY

(taking the half pill;
eyeing it like a
demotion)
It's the size of a hyphen,
Oswaldo.

OSWALDO
Progress, sir.

RANDY
(swallowing it; still
staring at the empty
case; the real subject
arriving)
Any word from Geneva?

OSWALDO
The gentleman in Geneva was a
hoax, sir. As was the gentleman
in Osaka, the widow in Tampa, and
the man who claimed his was
buried with his father.

RANDY
And was it?

OSWALDO
You paid to exhume the father,
sir. It was a Blastoise.

Randy closes his eyes. A man bearing up.

RANDY
A Blastoise.

OSWALDO
In fairness to the deceased, near
mint.

INT. BLISS MANOR -- SCREENING ROOM -- CONTINUOUS

Randy at a touchscreen wall. Oswaldo at his shoulder. On
screen: a corporate-espionage-grade dossier. Title slide:

INSERT -- SCREEN: "THE 1998 'CRYING CHARIZARD' PROMO.
Printed: 8. Confirmed surviving: 7. Location status
follows."

RANDY
 (reciting it like
 scripture; he needs no
 slides; the slides are
 for us)

Eight cards, Oswaldo. Printed for
 the eight finalists of the '98
 Osaka Invitational. The artist
 was going through a divorce --
 it's the only card in history
 where Charizard is crying. One
 single tear. He's still breathing
 fire. But he's crying while he
 does it.

(beat; hand to chest)
 It's the most emotionally
 complicated piece of cardboard
 ever made.

OSWALDO
 So you have said at four
 weddings, sir.

The screen flips through THE LEDGER OF EIGHT -- each card
 copy, numbered, with a status:

-- No. 1: POKÉMON COMPANY ARCHIVE, TOKYO. "Unbuyable. I've
 tried. There were lawyers."

-- No. 2: THE SMITHSONIAN. "Don't ask. There is a
 restraining order with my name spelled correctly."

-- No. 3: LOST AT SEA, 2003. Yacht "Papa's Bonus" went
 down off Catalina.

-- No. 4: SISTER BEATRICE, Carmelite convent, Fresno. Uses
 it -- unconfirmed -- as a BOOKMARK.

-- No. 5: UNKNOWN. Last seen changing hands in a Denny's
 parking lot, Reno, 2011.

-- No. 6: DESTROYED. A dog. There was a dog. We don't
 discuss the dog.

-- No. 7: "DUANE."

The screen just says DUANE, in red, with no other data,
 like a curse.

OSWALDO
 And number eight, sir?

Randy doesn't answer. The question is a formality; Oswaldo asks it the way you check a wound.

MATCH DISSOLVE TO:

EXT. CUL-DE-SAC -- MODESTO -- 1985 -- DAY [FLASHBACK]

Sun-bleached, VHS-warm. YOUNG RANDY, 11, chubby, radiant, holds a CARD in a plastic sleeve -- and around it the light literally bends, holofoil rainbows crawling the frame. The Shine, before we know its name.

Across from him: YOUNG DUANE, 11, a small boy with the eyes of a regional bank manager. He holds, sweating in the Modesto heat: one (1) CAPRI SUN. Warm. Fruit Punch.

YOUNG DUANE

Straight trade.

YOUNG RANDY

(licking dry lips; a
mouth like the Mojave;
eleven years old and
about to learn what
he's made of)

It's... warm.

YOUNG DUANE

Trade's the trade.

HOLD on Young Randy's face. The thirst. The card. The thirst. The card.

His hand extends the card in terrible slow motion --

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. BLISS MANOR -- SCREENING ROOM -- PRESENT

RANDY

(quietly; to the
screen; a man reciting
his own autopsy)
I didn't even finish it. It got
hot in the sun and I drank maybe
a third.

OSWALDO

I know, sir.

RANDY
He kept the pouch, Oswaldo. He
had it BRONZED. It's in his
lobby.

OSWALDO
I know, sir.

RANDY
(turning from the
screen; robe swirling
like a cape; the quest
declared for the
four-hundredth time but
today it has teeth)
Ledger says a copy surfaces at
Collect-A-Con Anaheim this
weekend. Number Five. The Denny's
card. It's real this time -- The
Laminator authenticated the
scans.

OSWALDO
The Laminator once authenticated
a Pikachu drawn in crayon, sir.

RANDY
He was younger then. We were all
younger then.
(heading for the door;
then stopping; the
other errand; his voice
dropping to something
human)
And Oswaldo -- we have to swing
by the MediSaver first. Refill
day.

OSWALDO
(checking a small
notebook; delicately)
Sir... refill day is Thursday.
Today is Tuesday.

A silence. Randy's jaw sets like a man hearing distant
artillery.

RANDY
Gloria.

INT. MEDISAVER PHARMACY -- VAN NUYS -- DAY

A strip-mall pharmacy. Fluorescent. A short line of ordinary citizens. And at the counter, in a lab coat, immovable as a continental shelf: GLORIA, 55, pharmacist. She has seen everything and dispensed exactly what was prescribed, when it was prescribed, since 1994.

Randy approaches the counter the way his security detail wishes he wouldn't: alone, smiling, leading with charisma.

RANDY

Gloria! You look radiant. New lanyard?

GLORIA

(not looking up)

It's Thursday, Mr. Bliss.

RANDY

See -- and this is fascinating -- it's actually Tuesday --

GLORIA

The refill is Thursday. Twenty-eight days. It was twenty-eight days last month and, in a twist, it is twenty-eight days this month.

RANDY

Gloria. G. I'm about to travel. Anaheim. High-stakes environment, lot of stimulation, lot of LED walls --

GLORIA

Thursday.

RANDY

(leaning in; lowering his voice; going to the move that has never once failed him in thirty years)

What if I told you... that there is a boat --

GLORIA

Mr. Bliss, if you offer me the boat again I am legally required to log it.

RANDY

It's a different boat.

GLORIA
(stamping something
with terrible finality)
Thursday.

Randy stands there. A man worth \$4.1 billion, at a linoleum counter, in front of the only human being on earth with an actual "no" in her.

Behind him in line, an OLD MAN with a cane:

OLD MAN
She's right, you know. Rules is rules.

RANDY
(wheeling on him;
catching himself
mid-wheel; smoothing
his jacket; the mood
spike arriving and
being ridden like a
mechanical bull)
That's -- you know what, that's a beautiful sentiment, sir, and I hope your hip gets better.

OLD MAN
It's a knee.

RANDY
(already leaving;
through teeth; with
feeling)
I picked the wrong day to quit smoking.

OSWALDO
(holding the door;
quietly)
You've never smoked, sir.

RANDY
Then it was Xanax. One of those.
It was somebody's wrong day,
Oswaldo.

EXT. ANAHEIM CONVENTION CENTER -- SATURDAY -- DAY

An aircraft-carrier of a building wearing an inflatable Pikachu the size of a church. Banners: "COLLECT-A-CON -- WEST COAST'S BIGGEST TRADING CARD EXPO." A river of humanity: kids, dealers, a man dressed as a Squirtle

arguing with security about his shell being a bag.

Randy's motorcade -- three black Escalades -- pulls up. Randy emerges in "civilian disguise": a bucket hat, sunglasses, and a T-shirt reading "JUST A NORMAL CARD GUY."

OSWALDO
(deadpan; assessing the
disguise)
Impenetrable, sir.

INT. COLLECT-A-CON -- MAIN FLOOR -- CONTINUOUS

BEDLAM. A thousand vendor tables. Glass cases of holofoil under halogen. A DJ, inexplicably. An autograph line for a man billed as "THE VOICE OF SEVERAL POKÉMON, ALLEGEDLY."

And LED WALLS -- enormous, strobing, everywhere.

Randy flinches at the light like a man being interrogated by it. He puts a second pair of sunglasses on over the first pair. Presses two fingers to his temple where the taper headache lives now, a small tenant with a lease.

OSWALDO
Sir?

RANDY
I'm fine. It's the half dose.
Doctor Nam says the headaches
are, quote, "the sound of the
brain remodeling."
(beat; squinting
through two pairs of
sunglasses)
My brain's doing an open-concept
kitchen, Oswald.

They push through the crowd toward Booth 404 -- and the crowd parts, and there it is:

BOOTH 404. A folding table. A locked glass case. And inside the case, on black velvet, under a single halogen spot:

THE CARD.

Crying Charizard. One tear. Still breathing fire.

And here comes THE SHINE -- the film's first full pour:

Randy arrives at the case. Presses one hand to the glass, gently, like visiting a relative in the hospital.

The sound CRASHES back in --

DEALER (O.S.)
NO TOUCHING THE GLASS.

Behind the table: the DEALER, 45, ponytail, fingerless gloves, a T-shirt of a wolf howling at a slightly different wolf. This is KEITH.

KEITH
You want to see the card, there's a viewing protocol. Hands behind your back. Breathe away from it. No flash photography -- the flash "excites the foil."

RANDY
(hands behind back;
breathing away from it;
utterly compliant; a
lamb)
It's Number Five. The Denny's card. Reno, 2011 --

KEITH
(narrowing his eyes)
Nobody knows about Reno.

RANDY
I know about Reno, Keith. I've been to the Denny's. I bought the Denny's.

KEITH
(recalculating this
customer entirely)
...It's not for sale. It goes to auction tonight. Private room. Invitation only. The list is locked.

RANDY
(removing both pairs of
sunglasses; then the
bucket hat; the full
reveal, like a knight
lifting his visor)
Keith. Look at me. Do you know who I am?

KEITH
(squinting; a long
beat; then, with total
confidence)
...You're the backup-beep guy.
The truck-beep billionaire.

RANDY
(a wound opening behind
his eyes)
That is DUANE. Duane HICKLE is
the beep. I am the DOOR WEDGE. I
am the reason hotel doors close
QUIETLY, Keith. I gave the
hospitality industry its SILENCE.

KEITH
(beat)
...The list is still locked.

RANDY
(putting the bucket hat
back on; to Oswald,
marching off; with the
gravity of Churchill)
Get me into that room.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

INT. COLLECT-A-CON -- SERVICE CORRIDOR -- NIGHT

Randy and Oswald, flattened against a wall like a heist team, watching a door marked "PRIVATE AUCTION -- CREDENTIALS ONLY." A bouncer the size of a vending machine checks lanyards.

A small voice from behind a stack of chairs:

DESTINY (O.S.)
You're doing it wrong.

They turn. From the shadows steps DESTINY, 9, gum, side ponytail, a binder under one arm thick enough to stop small-arms fire. She looks Randy up and down like a loan application.

DESTINY

You're the door-wedge guy. You've been to every big card show in the western region for three years asking about the Crying 'Zard. Vendors call you "Deep Pockets Sad Eyes."

RANDY

They call me --

DESTINY

Deep Pockets Sad Eyes. Yeah.

(cracking gum)

I can get you in that room. I run errands for the auctioneer. Badge access.

(she holds out her hand, flat)

Fifty bucks and your Escalade guy drives me to my nana's after. She's in Buena Park, it's like ten minutes.

RANDY

(to Oswaldo)

Pay her.

DESTINY

(pocketing the fifty; already walking; over her shoulder, the film's scariest negotiator establishing terms)

That was a test. It should've been five hundred and you folded instantly. We'll work on you.

INT. COLLECT-A-CON -- PRIVATE AUCTION ROOM -- NIGHT

A curtained ballroom section. Folding chairs, a podium, the CARD on a easel-mounted case under a spotlight. Forty bidders: collectors, two guys on phones speaking rapid Japanese, a woman with a falcon (unexplained, never addressed).

The AUCTIONEER -- tuxedo T-shirt, gavel that is clearly a rock-hammer -- takes the podium. Randy, in a borrowed STAFF vest over his disguise (Destiny's work), sits in the back row, vibrating.

AUCTIONEER

Lot One. The Reno Denny's Crying
Charizard. Authentication by The
Laminator himself --

(a murmur; someone
crosses themselves)

-- grade pending. Opening bid:
fifty thousand.

Paddles rise. The number climbs fast -- 75, 90, 120 --

Randy's paddle comes up: 150.

A phone-guy: 175. Randy: 200. The falcon woman: 225 -- via
the falcon lifting one wing, which the auctioneer accepts
without comment.

RANDY

(standing; done with
increments; the
door-wedge fortune
entering the room)

One million dollars.

Dead silence. The falcon looks at its owner. The owner
shakes her head, out.

AUCTIONEER

One million from the... staff
member. Going once --

And then, from the doorway, a VOICE. A voice like a truck
backing up -- flat, penetrating, engineered to be
impossible to ignore:

DUANE (O.S.)

Two million.

The room turns. In the doorway, flanked by two assistants
dressed identically to him: DUANE HICKLE, 52. Small. Neat.
The eyes of a regional bank manager, forty years matured
into the eyes of a regional bank. He holds -- and sips
from, slowly, maintaining eye contact with Randy across
the entire room -- a CAPRI SUN.

RANDY

(the word escaping him
like steam)

Duane.

DUANE
 (sipping; the pouch
 crinkling in the
 silence)
 Randolph.

AUCTIONEER
 (sensing history;
 delighted)
 Two million from Mr. Hick! Do I
 hear --

RANDY
 Three.

DUANE
 Four.

RANDY
 FIVE.

DUANE
 (examining his nails)
 Seven.

The room is a tennis crowd now. Destiny, by the curtain,
 watches with the face of a scout at a draft combine.

RANDY
 (sweating; the taper
 headache spiking; the
 LED spotlight suddenly
 very loud, if a light
 can be loud, and
 tonight it can)
 Eight... million dollars.

DUANE
 (and here he does it:
 he finishes the Capri
 Sun -- the long,
 wretched, air-sucking
 SLURP of a straw
 finding the bottom of a
 pouch -- into a
 microphone-quiet room,
 staring at Randy the
 entire time)
 Ten.

Randy opens his mouth. And his phone RINGS -- loud,
 unsilenced, the ringtone the Pokémon theme because of
 course it is. He fumbles it out: "DR. NAM."

RANDY
 (hissing into phone)
 Not NOW, Doctor --

DR. NAM (V.O.)
 (warm; clinical;
 oblivious)
 Randy, my system flagged that you
 attempted an early refill
 Tuesday. We talked about this.
 How's the headache, one to ten?

RANDY
 (eyes on Duane; on the
 card; on his life)
 TEN. Everything is ten!

DR. NAM (V.O.)
 That's the remodeling. Breathe
 into your belly, not your chest
 --

AUCTIONEER
 Ten million going once --

RANDY
 (phone in one hand,
 paddle in the other, a
 man being torn in half
 by two service
 providers)
 ELEVEN! -- not you, Doctor --
 ELEVEN MILLION --

AUCTIONEER
 Eleven from staff! Going once --
 going twice --

Duane raises one finger. Everything stops.

DUANE
 (quietly; to the room;
 a scalpel)
 Point of order. Is the gentleman
 even credentialed? He appears to
 be wearing a staff vest over a
 shirt that says "Just a Normal
 Card Guy."

Every head turns. The bouncer starts moving. Destiny
 facepalms into her binder.

RANDY
(backing toward the
fire exit; paddle still
raised; dignity in full
retreat)
I picked -- and I want everyone
in this room to know it -- the
WRONG DAY to quit Xanax!

OSWALDO
(appearing at his
elbow, steering him
out)
Smoking, sir. This morning it was
smoking.

RANDY
It's a RANGE, Oswald!

SMASH CUT TO:

EXT. ANAHEIM CONVENTION CENTER -- LOADING DOCK -- NIGHT

Randy sits on a milk crate, decredentialed, bucket hat in his hands. Oswald stands beside him. Inside, muffled, a gavel bangs: sold. To Duane. Ten million.

Destiny walks up. Sits on the next crate. Cracks her gum.

DESTINY
You bid like a tourist. You never
bid your feelings. Your feelings
were showing from space.

RANDY
(staring at nothing)
He drank the Capri Sun at me.

DESTINY
Yeah. That was cold.
(beat; she opens her
binder; flips
professionally; taps a
page)
Look. Number Five was always
going to Hickie -- he had it
bought before the room opened,
the auction was theater. He does
it to you every time. You know
why he does it to you every time?

RANDY

Because he's a small beeping demon.

DESTINY

Because you CHASE. Chasers pay retail.

(she snaps the binder shut; stands; delivers the act-one thesis with a nine-year-old's total authority)

You want a Crying 'Zard, Deep Pockets? Stop chasing the ones everybody knows about.

(beat)

Number Three's been sitting at the bottom of the ocean for twenty years, and the ocean doesn't know who you are.

Off Randy's face -- the Shine flickering at the edges of the frame, faint, like weather approaching --

RANDY

(standing; hat on; reborn)

Oswaldo. Buy me a submarine.

OSWALDO

(already dialing)

The yellow one, sir, or the serious one?

RANDY

(walking toward the Escalades, backlit by loading-dock light, cinema's stupidest hero shot played completely straight)

Both.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

EXT. PACIFIC OCEAN -- OFF CATALINA ISLAND -- DAY

A research vessel. Cranes. Crew. And swinging from the davits: a deep-sea submersible, serious and gray -- with, lashed to the deck behind it, inexplicably, a second, smaller, YELLOW submarine. Nobody discusses it. It is

simply there, like the falcon.

INT. SUBMERSIBLE -- DESCENDING -- DAY

Cramped. Portholes. Randy in a jumpsuit he has had TAILORED. Beside him, a marine salvage PILOT, 40s, and -- in a child-sized jumpsuit, having negotiated her way aboard through means the film declines to investigate -- DESTINY, with her binder.

PILOT

Wreck's at ninety meters. "Papa's Bonus," eighty-foot Ferretti, went down in the '03 swell. Owner got out. His card binder did not.

DESTINY

(reading from her own binder)

Number Three was in a fireproof, waterproof collector's safe. Bolted in the master stateroom.

(to Randy)

Waterproof for like thirty minutes, by the way. Twenty years ago. Manage your expectations.

RANDY

(face pressed to the porthole; the deep blue going deeper; whispering)

He's down there. Crying. In the dark. For twenty years.

PILOT

(to Destiny; quietly)

Is he talking about a card?

DESTINY

(flipping a page)

Don't make eye contact when he's like this.

EXT. THE WRECK OF "PAPA'S BONUS" -- SEAFLOOR -- CONTINUOUS

Floodlights find her: a yacht on its side, coral-crusted, fish schooling through the flybridge. The name still legible on the transom. PAPA'S BONUS. A grouper the size of a loveseat watches the submersible with municipal indifference.

INT./EXT. WRECK -- MASTER STATEROOM -- CONTINUOUS

The submersible's robotic arm peels back a corroded door. Inside, amid drifting silt and a school of garibaldi: THE SAFE. Bolted to the deck, exactly as promised.

And as the floodlight hits it --

RANDY

(whisper)

Open it. Open it down here. I want to be with him when he sees the light.

PILOT

Sir, protocol is we raise the safe --

RANDY

OPEN IT, GARY.

The robotic arm grinds the safe open in a bloom of silt --

-- and inside, in a rotted plastic sleeve, held gently up to the porthole by the arm:

A MAGIKARP.

Common. Not even holofoil. And -- visible even through twenty years of seawater -- LAMINATED. Home-laminated. Bubbles in the plastic.

Long silence. The whale song stops. A single sonar ping, like a sad bell.

DESTINY

(finally; scholarly)

Huh. So the Reno story was real. The guy DID swap it at the Denny's in 2011.

(flipping binder pages; connecting it)

Which means Number Three isn't down here. Number Three's been in circulation for fourteen years, mislabeled as Number Five --

(she stops; looks up; the math landing)

-- which means Hickie's ten-million-dollar card is the Denny's card, and the Denny's card was never --

RANDY
 (staring at the
 Magikarp; the beautiful
 terrible dawn of hope)
 -- was never Number Five.
 (turning to her;
 gripping the porthole
 frame)
 Then where's the REAL Number
 Five, Destiny?

Destiny licks a finger. Turns one page. Rotates the binder
 to face him.

INSERT -- BINDER PAGE: a grainy photo of a NUN, 70s,
 serene, in full habit, reading a Bible in a Fresno garden.
 Poking out of the Bible, unmistakable to the trained eye,
 one corner of orange holofoil, used as -- yes -- a
 BOOKMARK.

DESTINY
 Fresno, Deep Pockets. It's been
 in Fresno the whole time.

RANDY
 (to the pilot; eyes
 never leaving the
 photo; the Shine
 already gathering at
 the frame's edges like
 dawn)
 Gary. Surface. And someone get
 Oswald on the radio --
 (beat; with destiny,
 lowercase and
 uppercase, in his
 voice)
 -- I need a reason to be in a
 convent.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

EXT. CARMELITE CONVENT OF PERPETUAL QUIET -- FRESNO -- DAY

Adobe walls. A garden. Bees. A hand-painted sign: "ANNUAL
 CHARITY SILENT AUCTION -- SATURDAY -- ALL PROCEEDS TO THE
 ROOF."

A second, smaller sign, in the same serene hand: "THE ROOF
 IS VERY BAD."

INT. CONVENT -- VISITING PARLOR -- DAY

Spare. A crucifix. Two wooden chairs. In one: SISTER BEATRICE, 78, serene as a lake at dawn. In the other: Randy, in what his stylist described as "humble tycoon" -- a \$9,000 sweater the color of oatmeal.

On the table between them: her BIBLE. And peeking from Ezekiel, one corner of orange holofoil. Randy cannot stop looking at it. It's like a fishhook in his eye.

SISTER BEATRICE

You've come a long way, Mr.
Bliss.

RANDY

(eyes on the bookmark;
wrenching them up;
sweating oatmeal)
I -- yes. I heard about the roof.
I care very deeply about...
roofs. Roofing. The concept of
shelter, spiritually --

SISTER BEATRICE

(gently)
You've come about my bookmark.

Beat.

RANDY

(all pretense
collapsing at once,
like the roof)
It was my card, Sister. Not that
one -- one like it -- I traded it
when I was eleven for a warm
Capri Sun and I have spent
forty-one years and roughly two
hundred million dollars trying to
make one moment of thirst not
have happened.

Silence. Bees. Somewhere, a bell.

SISTER BEATRICE

(considering him a long
moment)

A novice gave it to me in 1999.
Her nephew was one of the Osaka
eight. She said the little dragon
was crying, and I should keep him
somewhere he could hear the
Psalms.

(she touches the Bible,
fondly)

He's been in Ezekiel a long time.
Bit of a demotion for him,
honestly, but the ribbon broke.

RANDY

Name a number, Sister. Any
number. I'll fix the roof. I'll
fix every roof. I will build you
a cathedral with a retractable
dome like the Cowboys have --

SISTER BEATRICE

(serene; immovable;
Gloria in a habit)

It's not for sale, Mr. Bliss.
(beat; and then, with
the faintest twinkle of
a woman who has read
the auction catalog)

It is, however, Lot Forty.
Saturday. For the roof.

(leaning in, confiding)

Silent auction. Which will be
difficult for you, I suspect. You
seem loud.

INT. CONVENT -- CHAPEL HALL -- SATURDAY -- DAY

Folding tables around the chapel perimeter. Casseroles. A
quilt. Lot 12: "MYSTERY JAR." And at the far end, Lot 40:
the BIBLE, open to Ezekiel, the card's corner gleaming. A
clipboard and a pen on a string beside it.

The rules, hand-lettered: "WRITE YOUR BID. HIGHEST AT 3 PM
WINS. SILENCE, PLEASE. GOD IS LISTENING AND SO ARE THE
SISTERS."

The hall is full: parishioners, locals -- and card people.
Word got out. Keith is here. The falcon woman is here, the
falcon wearing a tiny ribbon for the occasion. Two of
Duane's identical assistants circulate like beige sharks.

Randy enters -- and stops dead.

Across the hall, by the casseroles, sipping from a Capri Sun in a chapel: DUANE.

They lock eyes across forty feet of consecrated silence. Neither may speak. It is the Western standoff of the film, conducted entirely in eyebrow.

MONTAGE -- THE SILENT WAR, IN SILENCE:

-- Randy writes a bid on the Lot 40 clipboard: \$100,000. Underlines it. Walks away casually.

-- Duane glides in, reads, writes. Walks away. Randy returns: \$250,000 -- and beneath it, Duane's entry: \$250,001. Randy's nostrils flare. A NUN materializes at his elbow with a finger to her lips before he even inhales.

-- Randy writes \$1,000,000. Stares at Duane across the hall. Duane, without breaking eye contact, finishes his Capri Sun -- the SLURP obscene in the sacred quiet. Three nuns turn. Duane points at Randy. Randy mouths a word we cannot print in a chapel.

-- The bidding sheet fills. A second sheet is stapled on. Sister Beatrice, presiding by the Bible, watches the numbers climb with the tranquility of a woman watching God re-roof her convent in real time.

-- 2:58 PM. Randy writes his final number, shielding it with his body like a test answer: \$4,400,000. He caps the pen. Stands guard over the clipboard, arms crossed, a bouncer for a Bible.

-- Duane approaches for one last bid. Randy does not move. Duane reaches for the pen on its string. Randy steps on the string. The pen stops six inches from Duane's hand, taut. The two men look at each other. A nun's shadow falls over them both. Randy lifts his shoe, slowly, with enormous piety.

-- Duane picks up the pen. Reads Randy's number. Looks at Randy. And -- the film slows down here -- puts the pen back. Doesn't bid. Walks away with a small strange smile that Randy will replay for days and we, the audience, should file away too.

-- 3:00 PM. A handbell rings, once.

SISTER BEATRICE
 (the only voice
 permitted; reading the
 sheet; serene)
 Lot Forty. The little dragon goes
 to Mr. Bliss.
 (beat)
 The roof thanks you. The roof
 thanks you very much.

The hall applauds -- silently, hands fluttering in the
 air, nun-style. Randy stands there with jazz hands raining
 around him, receiving the Bible into his arms like a
 newborn, and the Shine floods the chapel -- stained-glass
 light bending toward Ezekiel, the one guy humming
 somewhere in the rafters --

RANDY
 (whispering, to the
 card, finally, after
 forty-one years)
 Let's go home.

EXT. CONVENT -- PARKING LOT -- MOMENTS LATER

Randy strides to the Escalades cradling the Bible. Destiny
 falls in beside him, Oswaldo behind, a papal procession
 with gum.

DESTINY
 Congratulations. You paid
 four-point-four for a card in a
 Bible with zero paperwork.
 (beat; the professional
 caveat)
 It's raw, Deep Pockets.
 Unauthenticated, ungraded. Until
 GradeCorp seals it, it's a rumor
 with a tear on it. Hickie's
 people will say it's the fake and
 his is real.

RANDY
 (supremely, dangerously
 serene)
 Then we grade it. Monday. The
 clean room. The full ceremony.
 (beat; to the sky; to
 the card; to Modesto,
 1985)
 Nothing on this earth can touch
 me now.

OSWALDO
 (quietly; checking his
 notebook; the smallest
 cloud crossing the sun)
 Sir -- gentle reminder --
 Thursday came and went during the
 convent reconnaissance. You never
 picked up the refill. You are
 now... several days into zero.

A beat. Randy's left eye twitches, once, delicately, like
 a seismograph registering something far away and enormous.

RANDY
 (still serene; mostly)
 I feel fantastic, Oswaldo.

DESTINY
 (to Oswaldo; low)
 His eye's doing the thing.

OSWALDO
 (low)
 I know. I'll pack the
 electrolytes.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

EXT. INTERSTATE 5 -- GRAPEVINE -- MONDAY -- DAWN

The Escalade convoy southbound. Fog on the pass.

INT. LEAD ESCALADE -- CONTINUOUS

Randy in the back, the Bible in a custom foam-lined case
 on his lap, seatbelted into its own seat. He has not
 slept; the zero-Xanax days show in a fine full-body hum,
 like a tuning fork somebody struck last Tuesday.

The convoy pulls into a GAS STATION.

EXT. GAS STATION -- GORMAN -- CONTINUOUS

Randy paces the parking lot while the tanks fill.
 Fluorescent light through the fog. He squints at it -- the
 light sensitivity now a full-time roommate -- and drifts
 inside.

INT. GAS STATION -- CONTINUOUS

Randy at the hot case. Inside, under heat lamps possibly older than he is: taquitos, rotating with the slow menace of a planetarium exhibit. And a lone, sweating BREAKFAST BURRITO in shrink wrap, marked down twice.

DESTINY (O.S.)

Don't.

She's in the snack aisle with a Gatorade, watching him like a lifeguard.

RANDY

I haven't eaten since the chapel.
My body is a temple and the
temple is CLOSED for renovation,
there's scaffolding everywhere,
and the temple wants the burrito.

DESTINY

Your whole deal is chemistry
right now. Doctor Nam said bland
foods. Oswaldo has electrolytes
and crackers in the car.

RANDY

(already at the
register; the burrito
warm in his hand like a
decision being made by
someone else)
Doctor Nam isn't the boss of the
temple.

Destiny watches him eat it in four bites, standing up, by the windshield-wiper display. She takes out her binder and, on a fresh page, writes something down. We don't see what. We don't need to.

INT. GRADECORP HEADQUARTERS -- SANTA ANA -- LOBBY -- DAY

A cathedral of authentication. Marble. Behind glass: famous graded cards displayed like crown jewels. A motto etched in stone: "CONDITION IS TRUTH."

A RECEPTIONIST in a blazer. Security like an embassy. Randy, Oswaldo, and Destiny at the desk, the foam case handcuffed -- Randy insisted -- to Oswaldo's wrist.

RECEPTIONIST

Mr. Bliss. GradeCorp is honored.
You've purchased our White
Ceremony package --
 (reading, with
 reverence)
-- witnessed authentication, live
grading, immediate encapsulation.
The card never leaves your sight.

RANDY

 (hand on the glass;
 already misty)
The full ceremony. He deserves
the full ceremony. He's been in
Ezekiel.

RECEPTIONIST

Of course, sir.
 (standing; grave)
You'll need to suit up. The
Chamber is a Class 100 clean
room. Positive-pressure garments,
sealed at the wrists and ankles.
Once the Ceremony begins, the
Chamber is locked and the air is
sacred.
 (beat)
There is no re-entry, Mr. Bliss.
And no early exit without
triggering full contamination
protocol.

A low, distant GURGLE. Everyone politely pretends it was
the building.

DESTINY

 (quietly; to Randy; the
 lifeguard again)
Bathroom's right there. Last
chance. I'm serious.

RANDY

 (striding toward the
 airlock, arms wide,
 destiny's idiot)
I've waited forty-one YEARS,
Destiny. The temple can wait
forty-one MINUTES.

INT. GRADECORP -- THE CHAMBER -- DAY

White. Silent. Beautiful. Air handlers whisper. In the center, under a surgical light: a single steel table. THE GRADER -- 60s, white bunny suit, magnifier loupe, the bearing of a man who has told popes their relics were reprints -- stands waiting.

Randy enters in his own bunny suit, sealed to the chin, hood up, only his face visible through the visor. Behind glass in an observation gallery: Oswald, Destiny, the receptionist -- and, arriving quietly at the back of the gallery with his two identical assistants, uninvited, entirely legal, holding a Capri Sun he cannot possibly have gotten through security: DUANE.

Randy sees him through the glass. Duane raises the pouch in a small toast.

GRADER
(sonorous; beginning
the Ceremony)
We are gathered to witness the
card.

The Grader unhouses the Bible with tongs. Opens it to Ezekiel. Lifts the card free -- and even the Grader, forty years in the business, pauses.

GRADER
...Oh, he IS crying.

And then, very quietly, inside the sealed positive-pressure suit, the burrito announces itself.

A GURGLE -- but this time miked like a submarine hull under pressure. Randy's face, through the visor, does a thing no bunny suit can hide.

RANDY
(small; to no one; to
God)
No.

GRADER
(oblivious; loupe down;
beginning the
examination)
Centering... fifty-five,
forty-five. Strong. Surface... my
word, the surface --

Randy begins to sweat. The suit -- sealed at wrists, ankles, neck -- is now a personal greenhouse for a developing weather system. He does the math on the

airlock: LOCKED. The sign inside the door: "EARLY EXIT = FULL CONTAMINATION PROTOCOL. ALL MATERIALS IN CHAMBER WILL BE IMPOUNDED."

He looks at the card. At the door. At the card. It is the Capri Sun trade again -- the body versus the grail -- and his face knows it, and through the glass DESTINY knows it, standing now, palms on the window.

RANDY
 (through teeth;
 clenched everything; a
 man negotiating with
 his own intestines like
 a hostage crisis)
 Not now. Not HERE. We are in a
 CATHEDRAL --

GRADER
 Corners... immaculate. Mr. Bliss,
 in thirty years I have never
 given the grade I am about to --

And the burrito, the taper, the fog, the four-point-four million, the forty-one years, all of it, arrives at once.

What follows, the film shoots like the tsunami it is:

-- WIDE: Randy goes rigid, then briefly, horribly relaxed.

-- THE GALLERY: Oswaldo removes his glasses. Destiny turns around entirely and faces the back wall, hand raised, done.

-- THE SENSORS: a wall panel of air-quality readouts, all green, and then -- one by one, left to right, like a slot machine paying out in hell -- flipping to RED. A klaxon. A calm recorded voice:

CHAMBER VOICE (V.O.)
 Particulate event detected.
 Particulate event detected. The
 Chamber is compromised.

-- THE GRADER: lowers his loupe. Looks at Randy. Says, with the same sonorous gravity as the opening rite:

GRADER
 Sir. Condition is truth.

-- STROBES. Foam-nozzled response teams pouring through the airlock. The card -- THE CARD -- lifted from the table with tongs, slid into an orange bag stamped CONTAMINATED

LOT, sealed, carried away from Randy's outstretched sealed-mittened hands as he is himself gently but firmly foamed.

RANDY
 (on his knees in the
 foam; howling through
 the visor; the line
 arriving at its most
 inappropriate possible
 altitude, as designed)
 I PICKED THE WRONG DAY TO QUIT
 SMOKING!

OSWALDO
 (through the intercom;
 heartbroken; loyal to
 the end and to
 accuracy)
 Xanax, sir. Today of all days, it
 was Xanax.

And through the gallery glass, in the strobing red light,
 Duane finishes his Capri Sun. SLURRRRP.

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. GRADECORP -- LEGAL CONFERENCE ROOM -- DAY

Randy, hair still foam-damp, in a GradeCorp-issue tracksuit, across a table from three LAWYERS and the receptionist, whose reverence has been replaced by paperwork.

LAWYER
 Per the White Ceremony agreement
 -- section nine, "Contamination"
 -- all impounded materials are
 decontaminated and then
 liquidated at bonded auction to
 cover remediation costs. You may
 of course bid.
 (beat)
 The lot is scheduled for CardCon
 Las Vegas. Three weeks.

RANDY
 It's MY card. I'll pay the
 remediation. I'll buy the
 chamber. I'll buy GradeCorp --

LAWYER

Mr. Hickle has already made a
stalking-horse bid on the lot,
sir. This morning.

(consulting a page;
delicately)

He also purchased the naming
rights to the incident. Legally,
what happened in that room is now
called "the Bliss Event."

Randy stares at the middle distance. Somewhere in the
building, faintly, a floor buffer runs over the scene of
his ruin.

INT. MEDISAYER PHARMACY -- VAN NUYS -- DAY

Rock bottom, fluorescent. Randy at Gloria's counter -- no
charm, no boat, no disguise. Just a tired man in a
GradeCorp tracksuit, several days past zero, holding his
little paper script like a peace treaty.

GLORIA

(taking it; scanning;
then, looking at him
for the first time in
the film like a person
instead of a policy)
...You look terrible, Mr. Bliss.

RANDY

I lost him, Gloria.
(beat; the whole thing,
simply)
I had him in my hands and my own
body took him away from me.

Gloria regards him. Then turns, works, and sets an orange
bottle on the counter. Slides it across.

GLORIA

Twenty-eight days.

(beat; and then, the
only free thing she has
ever given anyone)

Take it with food, Mr. Bliss.
REAL food.

(beat)

And for what it's worth -- my
grandson has that card in a
magazine picture taped over his
bed. Says the dragon's crying
'cause he's the strongest one and
nobody asks if he's okay.

Randy looks up at her. Something lands.

GLORIA (CONT'D)

Thursday next month. Don't be
early.

EXT. MEDISAVER -- PARKING LOT -- CONTINUOUS

Randy exits to find Destiny sitting on the hood of the
Escalade -- a violation Oswaldo is visibly permitting --
with her binder open.

DESTINY

Hickle put out a press release.
(reading)

"Duane Hickle, inventor of the
reverse-alert tone, will offer at
CardCon Las Vegas, at public
auction, TWO examples of the 1998
Crying Charizard promo: the
recently remediated 'Bliss Event'
card... and the Hickle Copy.
Provenance: acquired 1985,
Modesto. Consideration: one Capri
Sun, fruit punch, warm."

(she looks up)

He's selling YOUR card, Deep
Pockets. Both of them. In front
of everybody. He doesn't even
want the money.

RANDY

(quietly; understanding
his enemy at last; the
tuning-fork hum going
still)

No. He wants me in that room, in
a numbered seat, with a paddle.
He wants to watch me chase.

(beat; he opens the
pill bottle, shakes the
day's half onto his
palm, takes it with a
swig of Destiny's
Gatorade, hands it
back; the smallest
routine, finally done
right)

Then let's give him something
he's never seen me do.

DESTINY

Which is?

RANDY

(getting in the car;
the hero shot again,
but quieter now, and
earned)

Read the trade.

FADE OUT.

FADE IN:

EXT. LAS VEGAS STRIP -- NIGHT

Neon. Fountains. A billboard the size of a hockey rink:
"CARDCON LAS VEGAS -- THE AUCTION OF THE CENTURY -- 'THE
TWO DRAGONS.'" Beneath it, in genuinely enormous letters:
"FEATURING THE BLISS EVENT CARD."

RANDY (V.O.)

He named it after me. It's on a
BILLBOARD, Oswaldo.

OSWALDO (V.O.)

Try to think of it as a wing of a
hospital, sir.

INT. BLISS SUITE -- LAS VEGAS -- NIGHT -- [PREP MONTAGE]

The suite as war room. And the film's most responsible
montage:

-- Destiny at a whiteboard: "RULE ONE: NEVER BID YOUR FEELINGS." Randy, in a chair, repeating it like a catechism.

-- Oswaldo laying out tomorrow's kit: suit, paddle, and -- in a labeled dopp kit -- the orange bottle, a sleeve of crackers, a banana. The film lingers one beat on the banana. Chekhov's bland food.

-- Randy on the phone with DR. NAM, actually listening, actually breathing into his belly. Through the window behind him, Vegas strobes; he has taped a hotel towel over the worst of the LED glare, a small dumb accommodation, the kind real people make.

-- Destiny slides a page across the table: the Capri Sun trade, diagrammed like a football play. An arrow from CARD to DUANE. An arrow from POUCH to RANDY. And circled, at the bottom, in a nine-year-old's handwriting, the question the whole film has been walking toward: "WHAT DID HE ACTUALLY WANT?"

-- Randy stares at it. Flashback-flicker: 1985, the trade -- but for the first time the memory plays past the handoff. Young Duane, card in hand, standing there afterward, waiting -- waiting for something Young Randy, already drinking, already leaving, never gave him. The memory can't say what. Randy falls asleep in the chair with the page on his chest.

INT. CARDCON -- GRAND AUCTION HALL -- DAY

A thousand seats. Press risers. The falcon, in a bow tie. Keith, weeping quietly in row thirty, moved just to be here. Onstage, twin easels under twin spotlights: TWO CARDS. Two crying Charizards, side by side, like the world's smallest, saddest twins.

At a podium: a real AUCTIONEER this time, tails and gavel. In the front row, at last, face to face with the room he built: DUANE, flanked by his identical assistants. A cooler of Capri Suns at his feet, iced, like champagne.

Randy enters -- suit, paddle number 007 (he paid for the number) -- flanked by Oswaldo and Destiny. He walks past Duane. Stops.

RANDY
(quietly; no audience
for this but us)
Duane.

DUANE
 (not looking up)
 Randolph. Seat's marked. I bought
 you the good one. Sightlines to
 both.

RANDY
 (studying him; the
 diagram in his breast
 pocket)
 Why are you selling them?

DUANE
 (now looking up;
 regional bank eyes;
 unreadable)
 Everything's for sale, Randolph.
 You taught me that when we were
 eleven.

And there it is -- a hairline crack in the flat voice,
 forty years old, gone as fast as it came. Randy sees it.
 Files it. Takes his seat.

AUCTIONEER
 Ladies and gentlemen -- Lot One.
 The remediated card. "The Bliss
 Event."
 (a wave of laughter;
 Randy raises a hand and
 accepts it, graciously,
 like a man at his own
 roast)
 Opening bid: one million dollars.

THE BIDDING WAR -- and the film gives it the full Vegas
 fight-scene treatment:

-- Paddles like gunfire. Two, four, six million. Phone
 bidders. The falcon bids twice, gets a look from its
 owner, stops.

-- Randy bids CALM. Flat increments. Never his feelings.
 Destiny beside him with the binder, calling numbers like a
 caddy reading greens: "He's stretching. Let the phone guy
 burn out. Now."

-- At eleven million it's Randy and one phone bidder. At
 twelve, the phone bidder folds. The gavel hovers --

-- and the taper headache arrives, one last time, a white
 spike behind the left eye, the spotlights suddenly knives.
 Randy grips the armrest. Doesn't reach for the doppel kit.

Breathes into his belly. Peels the banana. EATS THE BANANA, in front of a thousand people, mid-auction, with total dignity. The headache crests. Passes.

AUCTIONEER
SOLD! The Bliss Event card -- to
Mr. Bliss! Twelve million
dollars!

The hall erupts. Randy sits perfectly still, one hand on his chest. He got one back. The room expects him to celebrate. He doesn't. Because --

AUCTIONEER (CONT'D)
And now. Lot Two. The Hickie
Copy. Provenance: Modesto, 1985.
(beat; reading, as the
hall goes quiet)
"Consideration: one Capri Sun.
Fruit punch. Warm."

The card Randy held when he was eleven rises on its easel.
And the Shine comes for him one final time --

DESTINY (O.S.)
(punching through the
Shine, the only voice
that can)
DEEP POCKETS. He's at THIRTY.
Phone bidders are dead. It's you
and him.

Sound crashes back. The hall. The board: \$30,000,000. And the bidder -- paddle raised, bidding on HIS OWN CARD, driving it into the sun, eyes locked on Randy: DUANE.

RANDY
 (standing in the aisle;
 understanding, finally,
 completely)
 He's not selling it.
 (to Destiny; to
 Oswaldo; to himself)
 He was never selling it. It's a
 trap with a bow on it. He'll bid
 until I break, and if I win, he
 wins, because I'll have paid half
 my life for it, and he'll still
 have the pouch in his lobby.
 (beat; the diagram; the
 crack in the flat
 voice; "he stood there
 waiting")
 Because money was never what I
 paid him.

Randy hands his paddle to Destiny. Walks down the aisle.
 The hall murmurs. Security twitches; the Auctioneer
 freezes; Randy stops at the front row, in front of Duane,
 and reaches into his jacket --

-- and takes out a CAPRI SUN. Fruit punch. He's carried it
 since Van Nuys.

He holds it out. Warm. It's been in a jacket for three
 weeks. It is disgusting. It is perfect.

RANDY (CONT'D)
 (quietly; a thousand
 people and no one but
 the two of them)
 Straight trade.

DUANE
 (staring at the pouch;
 the flat voice failing
 by degrees)
 The card's at thirty million
 dollars, Randolph.

RANDY
 I'm not bidding on the card,
 Duane. I'm re-running the trade.
 (beat)
 And this time I'm going to say
 the thing I didn't say when we
 were eleven. The thing you stood
 there waiting for while I walked
 away drinking.

The whole hall leans in. Duane's assistants lean in. The falcon leans in.

RANDY (CONT'D)
 (and he means it;
 forty-one years of
 appraisal, revised)
 It was a fair trade. You didn't
 cheat me. I was thirsty, and you
 had the only drink on the street,
 and you read the market and I
 signed. You won fair, Duane.
 (beat; holding out the
 pouch)
 I've just never been man enough
 to hear the beep.

A silence like the chapel. Duane looks at the pouch. At Randy. Forty years of press releases and bronzed trophies and naming rights, all of it built to force this exact sentence out of this exact man, and now it's here and it's free.

DUANE
 (finally; barely)
 ...It's warm.

RANDY
 Trade's the trade.

Duane stands. Takes the pouch. And -- in front of a thousand people, God, and the falcon -- lifts the card off the easel himself and puts it in Randy's hands.

The hall detonates. The Auctioneer, ruined, gavel nothing, repeatedly. Keith faints into the arms of the Squirtle guy. Destiny, on her chair, arms up, screaming like it's a title fight. Oswald removes his glasses for the second time in the film, for a different reason.

And Randy holds the card. HIS card. The Shine rises --

-- and settles. Gentle. No taffy ribbons. No choir guy. Just a man, in ordinary light, holding a piece of cardboard with a crying dragon on it.

Because that's the joke, and the not-joke: it was never the card that glowed.

DUANE
 (sipping the warm
 pouch; grimacing;
 delighted; the first
 honest face he's made
 in forty years)
 This is revolting.

RANDY
 I know. You get used to it around
 the third sip.

**INT. BLISS MANOR -- THE HALL OF THINGS -- DAY [ONE MONTH
 LATER]**

The empty case. The brass plaque that read "SOON" -- being
 unscrewed by Oswaldo and replaced with a new one: "1985 --
 2026."

Inside the case, on the velvet plinth: the CARD,
 encapsulated at last, graded -- we push in -- GEM MINT 10.
 And propped beside it, in its own tiny frame, with its own
 tiny plaque: a bronzed CAPRI SUN pouch. Plaque:
 "CONSIDERATION."

WIDER: the hall is not quiet. On the floor, cross-legged
 on a rug worth more than a house: RANDY and DESTINY,
 playing the actual card game with ordinary cards, arguing
 about a rule. Gloria's grandson is there too -- Randy flew
 him in; the kid is destroying them both. Somewhere a Capri
 Sun cooler sits open, iced.

Randy's phone buzzes. He checks it: "MediSaver -- Rx ready
 for pickup." He looks at the date. Thursday. Day 28, on
 the nose. He smiles, puts the phone away, and picks up his
 hand of cards.

DESTINY
 Your turn, Deep Pockets. And
 don't bid your feelings.

RANDY
 (laying down a card;
 utterly content; the
 last line of the film)
 Kid -- feelings are all I've got
 left. Everything else, I traded
 fair.

He plays his card. The kids groan. Off the case -- the
 dragon, still crying, still breathing fire, home -- the
 light bends, just barely, one last time.

39.

FADE OUT.

THE END